

Striking Out

The dark clouds looming ominously overhead slowly began to disperse just as the light was beginning to fade. Hardened, grey mountains broke the line of the horizon and they seemed to visibly frown on the bloody scene laid out before them. The landscape was dismal and devoid of life; blackened trees lay on the bare ground like skeletons that had yet to be bleached white by the sun. The land was silent – only the scent of blood and the lifeless bodies lying in the mud served as a tribute to the recent massacre.

A lone soul surveyed the battle field – a silver dragon, the shine of his scales diminished by the gloomy surroundings. He walked slowly forward, glancing at both the comrades and the enemies with their scales stained black by the blood of those they considered foes. He had to lift his feet high to clear the deep mud which had formed during the fight. The dragons had eventually turned to wrestling with each other on the ground, teeth and claws in their deadly array of weapons, when continuing in aerial combat became impossible due to the exertion it placed upon them. The storm, which had arrived during the latter part of the battle, had quickly transformed the torn ground into thick, black mud.

The mud clung degradingly to the dragon's scales, but in his mind he thought it was fitting in a way, that his scales should be sullied. There was no beauty in what he had done that day and there should be no splendour in his appearance either. He had no will to change his life; he knew he was no more than a tool that could be used all too often by others for the simple yet terrible purpose of destruction. So what right could have to outward beauty? His soul was already blackened by the lives he had taken. No, it was right for him to appear rough and dishevelled. In his heart, he felt he deserved no grace or favours awarded to him in any shape or form. He had done wrong that day and on countless days before. Again and again, he had stolen the right to life from others as easily as a thief lifts a precious jewel from its place of rest for his own personal gain. He had killed in cold blood.

He was ashamed to have been a part of the carnage.

The dragon snapped his head up as wing beats pounded the air mercifully – another dragon was approaching him rapidly. But he had no need to worry; it was a familiar shape that slowly took form and thankfully not another enemy for him to pit his skills against. He shook his tail uneasily from side to side, the tip flicking anxiously, while his friend approached. He had not been the only one to take innocent lives today.

The green dragon circled slowly above him, weariness clear in the tired line of his body, although his pale scales were not darkened by mud; he must have remained airborne throughout the killing. And in comparison to the silver dragon, he had a cheerful air about him – his eyes were bright and his maw was opened slightly in a relaxed position. He stared down at the silver dragon and roared a greeting, his eyes glinting with good humour when a raspy sound erupted from his muzzle. He ran his tongue around the confines of his mouth a few times, in an attempt to moisten it, before speaking again.

“Cadoc,” he called out, his voice echoing unnaturally in the barren landscape. “We are waiting for you; Jared’s called for you to join us. He says we need to be moving on again, that there are better spoils that what was claimed here today.”

Cadoc sighed deeply, his mind already turning sorrowfully to the thought of more bloodshed to come. The leader of his coven had seemed sane until the destruction had begun and his blood thirsty nature had been revealed to the others. Now Jared moved his coven quickly from territory to territory, gaining land and leaving bloody footprints in his wake. Although, Cadoc mused, Jared had never explained the reason for the endless need to conquer. But it was probably not necessary. Once a dragon joined a coven, he belonged to that coven for life, except in extraordinary circumstances. So why should his leader deign to explain what they others must obey regardless?

The mud sucked greedily at Cadoc’s legs as he stepped back carefully, spreading his wings to ready his body for flight. Then, with the last reserves of his strength, he pushed down hard with his wings and launched his body into the air, flapping his wings powerfully to gain altitude. The effort of flying at the point of exhaustion drove other, less welcome thoughts out of Cadoc’s mind, albeit briefly, and he relished in fighting the heavy air until he was at the same height as his companion.

It was better for him to fight the enemies which he could not see.

“Did Jared say why we are moving on so soon, Tadej?” Cadoc asked warily, keeping his voice even and trying to appear uncaring of the answer. The green dragon, Tadej, appeared to give the question careful consideration before answering.

“Does he ever, Cadoc? He’s not in his right mind. He keeps going on about the battle,” Tadej paused and bared his teeth in a ferocious draconian grin at Cadoc. “I will tell you as we fly – the others are near.”

Cadoc dipped his head in agreement and the two broke off from their circle, silver following green through the dying light. They drew quickly away from the battle grounds, using the wind, now at their backs, to assist them in their departure. But Cadoc couldn’t resist the urge to look back one last time. The sky was cloudless and the sun was setting, spilling scarlet light across the landscape. The light bathing the still bodies lying there in a bloody radiance was strikingly akin to the dried blood coating the fallen. The only difference between the warm glow of the sunset and the bloodshed was that the sun had no ill intentions or desire to harm. All she desired was to bring the light needed to this darkened world, day after day.

For a short while, Cadoc enjoyed the feeling of cool air rushing past his scales, but an awkward silence had fallen over the two dragons and Cadoc cast about his mind for something to nudge the conversation into motion once more. After all, if he was to expect more trouble from his leader, he would prefer to be informed of it sooner rather than

later. He glanced over Tadej's body and his eyes alighted on a long gash on Tadej's flank, dripping dark blood as he flew.

"You were injured in the fight," Cadoc observed quietly, twitching his tail in sympathy for his wound. Tadej glanced down as if surprised to see the injury.

"A mere scratch. One of the enemy caught me unawares during the fight. An underhand trick it was," Tadej replied, a sly grin distorting his features. Cadoc realised that he was about to launch into an explicably detailed account of his part in the battle, cunningly side stepping the real topic.

"Was Jared involved in much of the battle?" Cadoc asked, stubbornly refusing to be sidetracked. Tadej hesitated for several long seconds before answering.

"No, he wasn't . . . I didn't really see much of him . . . But perhaps he just wasn't in my sight," Tadej chuckled deeply, the sound rasping in his dry throat. "I was a little preoccupied defending my own tail, you see."

"Tadej," he snapped, a little more harshly than was necessary, since his friend flinched as if he had been bitten. "Say what has happened and don't avoid the subject. It's best to be prepared for whatever is waiting for us when we rejoin the coven."

Tadej nodded once and flapped his wings harder for a couple of beats to gain a fraction more height then began speaking in a rush, the words running together almost indecipherably as they tumbled off his tongue.

"He's changed so much recently – I used to believe he was a good leader, always looking out for the rest of the coven and doing what was best for everyone, but I must have been wrong. After what I heard today, I think differently. I can't tell you much of what he said because I don't remember or understand it myself, but he was going on about power and more battles like a mad thing he was. None of it made any sense to us. In the end, we left him to his ramblings."

"I have nothing against fighting; I am a good fighter and have no fear for my life in battle. I just like to know why I am fighting," Tadej added with a bitter note to his voice that Cadoc was surprised to hear. Tadej had always given the impression that he thrived in the chaos and mayhem of these massacres, always emerging from them with tales of triumphant and so called heroic kills he had made.

But it wasn't a subject he wished to discuss now, since Tadej had begun to angle down towards the ground. Cadoc cursed under his breath and filed away Tadej's words in the back of his mind for later reference, for he fully intended to breach the topic again. For now, he needed to see for himself the state of his leader.

The duo dipped into a gentle dive, aiming for a cluster of boulders, which were sheltered by a rather foreboding ridge rising above them. At first, Cadoc thought there was nothing

there but uninviting grey stones. However, when he looked closer, he caught a glimpse of red scales glinting at the edge of the shadows. Cadoc was forced to suppress a shiver of apprehension; it was their leader, Jared, standing half in the shadow of the ridge. Drawing nearer, the last member of their coven was revealed – Sadaki lay curled against one of the boulders in a ball of striking blue scales that rose and fell gently as he breathed.

Tadej and Cadoc landed in a clatter of claws, loudly announcing their arrival. Sadaki awoke with a start, his muscles tensing up for an instant before he relaxed again, baring his teeth in a welcoming grin for his friends. Despite his exhaustion, Sadaki's grin was infectious and Cadoc responded with an amiable, if weary, smile in return. It was good to see his friend in one piece at least.

Jared snorted derisively to Cadoc's right and he turned reluctantly to face their leader, who appeared to be in just as strange a disposition as Tadej had let on only a few minutes before. His eyes were narrowed, the sickly yellow orbs twitching restlessly in their sockets while he shifted the weight of his bulky body from one clawed foot to the other. Immaculate, ruby scales crowned every inch of his body and his outward appearance was so flawless, Cadoc would have sworn that Jared had not participated in the fight at all. Only one of his upward curved horns was broken – but that was a testimony to a battle won in the distant past, not a recent battle-scar.

The two dragons surveyed each other carefully, both of an equal build and well matched strength – if they had ever become locked in a fight, it would be difficult to tell which one would be the victor. Cadoc fought with himself to remain still as Jared let his gaze sweep over him, taking note that Cadoc bore no visible marks from this battle. Finally, after a long silence, Jared spoke.

“I see that you stragglers have deigned to join us,” he said evenly. “See that you are not late rejoining the coven in future.”

Cadoc was too tired to bite back with a scathing reply – he was fairly sure by this point that Jared had played a very small part in the battle – and instead nodded without a word and settled down on the hard stones a little distance from the others. Jared turned to the others, shifting his attention from Cadoc so quickly that it was almost as if the dragon bored him.

“We have done exceptionally well today and I am very pleased with how this coven is growing in might and power. We will become unstoppable, but there is more to be gained before we can declare that title for ourselves. This victory and those which are now in the past is only the beginning. There is far more to be claimed, more power to be won in the glory of battle.”

His eyes were brighter now and more feverous, adding an untamed edge to his words that stirred the eagerness for death in his followers. Impressions flashed through Cadoc's head with blinding speed – the steely rasp of claws on scales, a crimson sunset touching his silver scales with blood, his triumphant roar as his enemy tumbled to the ground, fatally

wounded. Jared's insanity was contagious in the most deadly way possible. As Cadoc fought with the primal part of him salivating for the closure of jaws on flesh and the screech of sharp fangs tearing mercilessly through scales and sinew, Jared continued speaking, oblivious to the turmoil inside Cadoc.

"We must move quickly. We must keep moving and gaining territory for our coven to hunt. Land is power and power is status. We will be feared, others shall *cower* when they hear our names spoken in hushed tones in the dead of night. Tomorrow, we fly north and our target will be the coven of seven living on the borders of humanity. We shall meet them in battle by noon."

The coven was silent for a full minute that stretched unnaturally, taking care to digest Jared's words cautiously. Cadoc was momentarily diverted from his internal battle, because a more practical part of him thought that he would have to be well rested this night if he wasn't to lose his life the next day. Sadaki was the first to break the silence, which was unusual for him, since he was the quietest of the coven and the least likely to question his leader's orders.

"Jared," Sadaki spoke up uncertainly. He winced when Jared locked him in his gaze; he was clearly angry at the question that was undoubtedly coming. "What if there are humans around at the time of battle? We can't take a risk like that – we can't be exposed to them."

Cadoc was surprised by Sadaki's sudden compassion, this was very unusual for the quiet follower, and he looked expectantly to Jared, whom he was sure would reconsider the decision to attack another coven so soon and with so little rest. But his hopes were dissipated almost as quickly as they had formed when Jared flapped his wings once, dismissing Sadaki's concerns.

"That is none of our concern. If some choose to interfere, to disrupt us in our quest, then of course they shall have to be eliminated. We cannot have our existence leaking through gaps in our defence to humanity – these gaps must not exist."

Cadoc thought he couldn't have heard Jared right. Surely he wasn't even suggesting that they take the lives of humans, whose affairs were no concern of theirs. They had no part in the lives of humans and by taking the lives of even a few, the fates of the two species would touch each other for the first time in centuries. Not to mention that even more innocent lives would be lost; Cadoc suppressed a shudder at the thought and tried to conceal the anger flashing in his eyes.

"Let me get this straight," Cadoc growled, struggling to keep his voice steady as the anger which had disturbed his façade earlier now threatened to overcome him. "If humans do cross our path in this next battle, we are to simply kill them – murder them? I understand the need to keep our kind a secret from the likes of men, but this is *barbaric*, even for you."

Jared rounded on Cadoc with an outraged snarl that made Sadaki cower and Tadej flinch in sympathy. Cadoc, however, held his ground, meeting his leader's furious gaze with his own.

"Do you question my authority as your leader?" Jared snarled, his words laced with fury as he took a step forward that put him muzzle to muzzle with Cadoc, who still refused to back down.

"It's not your authority I question, Jared, but your sanity," he replied bluntly. The others gasped at his raw nerve in saying such a thing and Cadoc regretted it instantly. Jared hissed as he drew in a shocked, livid breath and then released his tirade on to Cadoc.

"How dare you, insubordinate. Do you believe you have a right to your words because you have survived another battle? Have you forgotten that we fight together here, that we make decisions together? We have all survived these battles *together*. This coven is on the brink of owning the most territory across this land and you dare to question me. What we want is power and we will achieve that together, but not if hatchlings throw wild assumptions about my mental disposition and our cause around. If you question me, Cadoc, you can only truly question your own sanity in following me."

When he was finished, the only sound amongst the boulders was the heavy breathing of the two dragons who stood nose to nose, but couldn't see eye to eye. Cadoc looked away first, his anger already beginning to fade as common sense told him that he had made a hasty move. Jared, sensing his deference, growled curtly as Cadoc took two slow, hesitant steps back, hating himself for submitting but also knowing that it was the only thing he could do now.

I shall never be like you, he told Jared in the silent confines of his mind. You may rejoice in killing and thirst for power, but I cannot and I will not. For now, I shall give the appearance of obeying you, for the sake of the coven and nothing else. But in my heart I know that this is wrong and it shall always be wrong.

This was one battle he wanted to fight. He wanted to fight for himself so that he didn't have to live in the shadow of one whose heart had been stained black by sin. He needed to escape this madness polluting his life.

If he didn't, it would kill him.

Throughout this unspoken conflict, Jared watched Cadoc carefully, observing him with a sharp eye to ensure that his deference was not a trap. Satisfied, he snorted, a thin tongue of fire licking Cadoc's scales hungrily, and then made to walk away, turning back once.

"Tomorrow you shall go into battle first. Perhaps it will sweeten your attitude some."

Cadoc bristled and opened his mouth to respond but Tadej swung his tail sideways, knocking some pebbles so that they clattered against the rocky ground. When Cadoc

looked at him, he shook his head slightly, imploring Cadoc to hold back his scathing reply. Jared remained oblivious to this brief exchange and continued speaking.

“There will be no more talk of what has happened – it is of no importance to us. Instead, we shall speak of victories past. What new triumphs have you three to add to the grandeur of our coven?”

Night fell quickly, wrapping the dragons in a velvet cloak that concealed them from intruding eyes. Of course, they could see each other perfectly well even in the pitch black that descended – their eyesight was by far superior to any other creature, even those which were nocturnal.

As if nightfall had granted some unseen permission, the talk of killing began to escalate, as each dragon attempted to outdo the other with grotesque descriptions of wounds and how they had each ended numerous lives. Cadoc felt distinctly sick as he listened to them and made an effort to tune the conversation out. Laying his head on the ground and closing his eyes, he tried in vain to drift into a much needed sleep. But with the others talking about matters he wished never to think of again, he couldn't stave off the faces of those he had killed. He could see the images of them in perfect detail through his tightly closed eyelids and the eyes in the images were dark, accusing. He tried furtively to suppress the feeling that they were judging him for his murders.

I've done nothing truly wrong, he pleaded with them in the silence of his mind while a pained whimper escaped from his muzzle. *I am a dragon; I am following the leader of my coven. It is what I am supposed to do. Why do you haunt me so?*

But the dead had no answer for him and their cold stares were unyielding.

Cadoc's eyes snapped open. He had to get away – he had to escape from the madness somehow. His eyes roamed the boulders wildly as he searched for any means of distracting himself from these thoughts, yet there was nothing. Nothing in this place, near those he had to call friends, to save him from himself. He had to get away.

He heaved himself gracelessly to a standing position with a growl and shook himself thoroughly. Some scales that had been torn loose in the fight clicked against each other in a reminder that he was indeed a murderer. The others watched his actions in surprise, halting in the middle of their conversation. Under their shocked gaze, Cadoc lowered his head, finding himself suddenly unwilling to meet their eyes.

“I'll be back before dawn,” he hissed bitterly under his breath, before spreading his wings and, with a powerful downward motion, launching his body into the air, beating his wings hard to ascend quickly and leave the others far behind, but only physically.

But his soul remained behind, tied to them who sat so casually debating the carnage they had caused. It never mattered how hard he strived to break free of the chains which bound him to them; he would always be a part of their endless butchery, their endless

plotting and their endless scheming. And it killed him to know what his life had truly become, what he had become.

He had become a monster.

The night had closed in around him as he gained altitude and he noticed for the first time in many weeks that the night was dark, clouded over to such an extent that neither the stars nor the moon graced the land with their comforting presence. Looking back, he could see the ridge where he had left his companions steadily growing smaller and smaller, until even his eyes could not distinguish the location any longer.

It was a relief to him when the country began to look unfamiliar to him – it was a much needed distraction at the very least. Now, an imposing mountain range stretched out beneath him, the tall, dark crags visible even in the darkness. There was sparse vegetation around – in some places, copses of trees huddled together for protection, but the daring trees that had the strength and perseverance to take root alone in this land were stunted and weather beaten. The lush grass passing below told him that rain came often in this place, but the wind that only pressed lightly on his wings now must have been brutal most of the time.

A burning dryness in Cadoc's throat reminded him that he had not drank or eaten since well before the battle. Sighing deeply at the need to interrupt his solitary flight, he angled his wings so that his course was altered and he was heading in the direction of falling water. If it was a waterfall he could hear, he hoped there would be a large pool below it so that he could wash the blood from his scales after he drank. Perhaps there would even be some animals drinking from the pool too that he could use to satisfy his hunger?

He was circling high above the waterfall, scanning the ground diligently for the best place to land, when he noticed two small creatures by the waterfall's pool. And they were behaving in a very strange manner indeed.

To his eye, they had the appearance of normal horses, but with unusual coats, which were far more silver-grey than was considered normal. They had floating manes and tails that almost seemed to shine with the essence of moonlight, if it had been reflected off the surface of the water. They were diving in and out of the pool, shaking their heads as they did so, and then trotting up out of the water with excited neighs. Cadoc watched in astonishment as one leaped right through the pounding water of the falls, from a dangerously slippery ledge on one side, only to land soundly on the soft grass lying on the other side of the falls. The distance the horse had cleared in a single leap was at least ten metres.

Cadoc hesitated, tipping his wings a little so that he spiralled upwards very slowly; these creatures were like nothing he had ever seen before. Still, he was hungry and if these creatures could provide him with a meal, he certainly wasn't averse to killing them, whatever they were.

The hunger gnawing at his belly like a wild animal made his decision for him – he had to catch a meal while he had the opportunity. Cadoc set his jaw and locked his wings, jackknifing downwards in a steep dive, which rapidly increased in speed.

The two horses looked up from the edge of the water as he roared above them, opening his maw wide in anticipation of the kill. His dive was perfect – he could feel it in the way the wind sped past him and the unflawed tilt of his body; saliva began to rise in his maw in his eagerness. He knew they couldn't escape him in time; he was the ultimate predator of the skies and none could defy him of a meal.

He was disconcerted when his prey stood stock still, seeming almost unconcerned as he hurtled towards them, a terrifying mass of silver scales and deadly claws. A flicker of doubt passed through his mind for just a second. He had already stretched out his claws to snatch his prey off the ground and had expected a short chase before he claimed one of them for his meal. Briefly, he tried to understand why they hadn't run away – maybe they were exhausted after their game in the water – then forced it from his mind, concentrating solely on catching them. He was too close to back out of the kill now.

His hiss of triumph as he went to seize his meal was abruptly cut off in shock as his claws grasped at empty air. Shocked by what had happened, he flapped his wings in an ungainly fashion to stay aloft, barely succeeding in remaining above the water of the deep pool.

He landed without grace on the far side of the pool and then looked back quickly to see where the horses were. They were still standing on the opposite side of the pool, in the exact same position as they had been when he first began his attack – only their heads seemed to have turned to follow his movement as he failed to claim them. Cadoc shifted uneasily. What were these creatures, to evade a hunter like him?

One of the creatures pivoted on his hind legs – for it was clearly a male – pawing the air with his front hooves and giving a shrill neigh. The low roar of the tumbling waterfall close by was loud, but not loud enough to disguise the bubbling laughter in the neigh. Cadoc bristled visibly, his anger, which was so often close to the surface these days, rising almost unexpectedly inside him. How dare this animal laugh at him?

“What are you?” He snarled at them, not bothering to conceal his anger as he snapped his jaws and flapped his wings threateningly. “Why do you laugh? Are you not frightened of a nightmare like me?” The two horses looked at each other, laughing quietly to themselves as if they didn't *quite* wish to insult Cadoc by laughing out loud. Yet, they were still heard and Cadoc gritted his teeth, willing himself to keep a hold on his fury.

He grunted in surprise when the horses suddenly bounded forwards to gallop fluidly to the very edge of the water. They then proceeded to rock back on their hind legs to propel their slight bodies into an elegant leap over the gently shining body of water, moving in unison with each other, and landed gently on the other side, a few metres in front of Cadoc.

Cadoc stepped back hurriedly, not wanting to be too close to these unknown creatures. His tail flicked from side to side uneasily, although he tried to hide his discomfort and appear unaffected by their presence. Now that they were closer to him and his eyes weren't blinded by the thrill of impending bloodshed, he saw that they weren't just a strange colour – an otherworldly glow emitted from their very bodies, making the shape of them shimmer as they moved.

Overhead, the clouds parted, showing the half moon to the world again and illuminating the landscape with a touch of silver. The horses neighed delightedly and whipped around in a circling, manes and tails flying wildly, as they played in the moonlight, which only served to enhance the supernatural sheen of their coats.

“What are you?” Cadoc hissed, completely unnerved by the appearance of the creatures and the way they flickered and danced under his gaze. “You are nothing I have seen before in this world. And are you not afraid of a dragon like me?”

“Oh yes, we’ve seen your kind many times, many times,” one of the horses snickered, prancing on the spot. “We know what *you’re* capable of, my friend, we most certainly do!”

“So you have seen us and you have seen what we can do,” Cadoc said with a bitter edge to his voice. “Then you know I am a monster. Why are you not afraid of me?”

“Because calling yourself a monster is hardly a threat to *us!*” They squealed, scarcely able to remain standing at this point because their sides were shaking with suppressed laughter. Cadoc growled, a low, menacing sound deep in his throat, feeling his nervousness disappear only to be replaced by a stronger irritation as they continued to find something about him incredibly amusing. They weren't fazed at all by him; if anything, his obvious irritation only seemed to make them snort harder with mirth.

One of the horses danced up to Cadoc and lifted himself gracefully on to his hind legs so that he was almost nose to nose with the dragon, whose long neck was arched with his head lowered slightly to look down on the creatures. He squealed and playfully batted the air below Cadoc's head, swinging round as he did so to fling his body forward in a flying buck and land back at his companion's side.

“They call me monster because they don't understand me,” the smaller of the two horses sighed deeply, dipping his head down in mock sadness. “They called me Afanc and threw me out of the herd because I tempt human travellers to mount me. Then when I get tired of them I throw them to the ground.”

The other horse bumped the first playfully with his nose and then nipped his neck lightly when he didn't respond. Cadoc jumped when the smaller horse's head suddenly flew up as he reared, batting the other horse's withers and chest mischievously in a game. The other fended him off with a mock squeal of indignation then whinnied cheerfully at him.

“We know what they think of us, Afanc. Don’t you remember how the called me the impulsive one – and that’s putting it *too* kindly!” He turned back Cadoc, who stood slightly confused through their exchange, although he did manage to gleam that the name of the smaller horse was Afanc. “I am Idris, the *ardent master*!” He laughed, the sound peeling through the otherwise still night; Cadoc worried for a second that the sound would bring the other dragons to them but, as if they guessed his thoughts, the two horses shook their heads in denial.

“We can’t be heard – only if we *choose* to be heard!” The horses laughed, digging their hooves into the ground to send clods of rich earth flying behind them as they leaped forward and circled Cadoc.

“Better seen and not heard,” Afanc neighed loudly as if to emphasise his point; Cadoc winced as the sound hurt his ears for a split second before it died.

“What *are* you?” Cadoc asked, unable to restrain his curiosity. The two horses laughed again, the sound of their amusement echoing eerily through the silent night as they pranced around Cadoc.

“What are we?” They cheekily repeated the question in perfect unison. “Why – don’t you know? Have you never seen our kind before? What a life you must have been leading! We are the ceffyl-dwr of course.”

Cadoc tilted his head to one side in puzzlement. He had never heard of such a creature. Surely, he had seen many horses in his time but none that could be compared to these silver mischief makers who danced in the moonlight. They noted his confusion and the fact that he still didn’t understand them and what they were; the horses sniggered, their sides shaking with glee as Cadoc looked on.

“And he *still* doesn’t know who we are!” Idris nickered, tossing his head from side to side in amused disappointment. “Then we shall have to explain, shan’t we, Afanc?”

“Indeed we shall, Idris! Indeed we shall!” He replied with a little half-rear of excitement.

“Most call us *water horses* – we come from the waterfalls and mists to wreak havoc on the world,” Afanc began with a derisive snort. “I can’t say this is true, we just like to play with the humans; they’re so easily deceived, aren’t they, Idris?”

Idris nodded his head in agreement.

“But it is a dangerous game we play at times, Afanc,” he added after a moment of thought.

“Life is a game,” Afanc snorted, dismissing Idris’s comment with a flippant toss of his mane. “Some win, some lose, some cheat, some live, some die. That is life.”

Cadoc shook his head slowly, a bit bewildered by their explanation but they looked to be good enough creatures, even if they were a bit strange. He couldn't help feeling a faint glimmer of warmth towards them, they were likeable enough creatures.

"So," Cadoc began and the ceffyl-dwr looked up at him expectantly, anticipating another question, but Cadoc was reluctant to continue. It seemed intrusive to ask questions of these creatures, however happy they were to answer them. And if Cadoc was completely honest with himself, they made him slightly nervous. They were so unpredictable – he couldn't possibly anticipate what they were going to do next.

"Who do you follow?" Cadoc finally asked, his curiosity getting the better of him, for these two strange creatures seemed to be on equal terms with each other – one wasn't dominant over the other. They looked at him in surprise then exploded with laughter yet again. Cadoc glared at them and shuffled his wings indignantly at their mockery of him; he had thought it was a very fair question. Surely every being had a leader of some sorts and it was only right of him to enquire?

"We follow no one!" They chorused, pawing the air with their front hooves in perfectly timed unison. "We have no reason to be a part of a herd that has rules and patterns to follow. We break free of the norm in this world – we are *free*."

Free. The word flowed through Cadoc like ripples on a lake as he slowly realised, seeing these two free spirits prancing and laughing around him, that it was something that he had never known. He had never known what it was like to follow his own rules since he had always had a leader to follow. There had always been a reason to be a part of a coven and therefore, to him, there had always been a need for a leader. And in all truth, *free* was a word he had never heard before – freedom was a concept he had never understood.

"What?" Afanc whinnied curiously, digging one hoof forcibly into the ground when Cadoc remained silent. "It seems like this is not something you have heard of before. We are free. Are you not free?"

Cadoc sighed deeply, awkwardly lowering his unwieldy body to the ground.

"You have seen my coven, yes?" Cadoc enquired, unsure of exactly how much they already knew about him and his kind. They bobbed their heads in unison, giving him the encouragement he needed to continue.

"Then you know what we do. My leader wishes us to gain more and more land until... Well... Actually I don't know when we will stop with the killing," Jared sighed heavily and lay his muzzle down on the ground, feeling very tired all of a sudden. "I don't want to be a part of it, but he is my leader, what can I do?"

The horses regarded him seriously, Idris shaking a foreleg in the air as he mused over Cadoc's words. When he spoke, it was without laughter, it was with concern.

“Do you want to kill?” Idris asked simply, walking up to the dragon to touch his scaled leg softly with his velvety muzzle. Cadoc shook his head vigorously, sweeping it back and forth across the grass without bothering to lift his head.

“No, I don’t wish to kill, I hate it,” he replied bitterly, closing his eyes at the thought of killing another innocent dragon. “I have to kill to eat, but that’s all I want to do – I don’t want to take innocent lives when there is no need for others to die because of me!”

The ceffyl-dwr looked at each other; they had certainly not been expecting to be told anything of this nature. Idris shifted his weight from hoof to hoof, gazing up at the moon that was still shining brightly above the trio, but found no inspiration from it. Afanc, on the other hand, shook his body, dipping his head down to lip thoughtfully at the grass, before snapping his head back up again, a delighted whinny on his lips.

“Then leave, it’s that simple!” Afanc whinnied happily, kicking his hind legs back in glee. His companion bobbed his head in agreement, nuzzling Afanc’s side affectionately and congratulating him on the idea.

“It’s not that simple,” Cadoc sighed, sweeping his tail over the grass in frustration.

“Why not?” They chorused, both looking surprised that he had not jumped for joy as soon as they had supplied him with a way out of his situation.

“I am a dragon – a dragon always belongs to a coven. We cannot leave. Do you always think solutions are this simple?” He replied harshly, pushing himself back to his feet and glaring at them. “Are you so naive that you believe solutions are easy to find?”

Instead of being offended by Cadoc, the horses snorted and thought some more before replying. Idris swatted the air furiously with his tail, batting away imaginary flies that were bothering him, and it was Afanc who eventually answered, choosing each word with unexpected care.

“Things are simple to us, solutions are simple. Carrying them out is another story sometimes but we always get them done,” Idris paused, then came up to Cadoc’s side and flicked his flank lightly with his silver tail. “Listen, dragon, what is your name?”

“Cadoc,” he answered, turning his muzzle away. He didn’t want to look at the horses any more, but both of them flitted forward until they were directly in front of his muzzle and he was forced to have them in sight.

“Cadoc,” Afanc repeated, trying out the sound of the name in his mouth. “You’re not happy, are you?”

“Do you always ask such obvious questions?” Cadoc retorted with a wry smile playing across his muzzle as a spark of his old humour came forth. Afanc snorted and pranced at the retort.

“Too true, too true, dragon! But, Cadoc, you should come with us!” Afanc nickered quietly, proposing the idea and saying no more as he danced his shimmering form back and forth beneath the dragon’s nose. Idris seemed delighted with the idea, rearing up and striking the air with his small, grey hooves while letting out a high pitched squeal.

“Come with us, come with us! Oh, that is a fine idea indeed, Afanc!” He almost shrieked in his excitement, losing his balance and falling backwards on to the grass. Cadoc started, ducking his head down quickly to make sure the little horse was okay. Afanc giggled happily on his back with his legs in the air for a while, until his mirth subsided and he rolled back on to all four legs again, heaving himself up and looking enthusiastically to Cadoc.

“You must come with us,” he enthused with his eyes shining, although Cadoc was not convinced and turned his head away, staring at the pounding water of the waterfall. The rushing water poured down in an unstoppable torrent and Cadoc swore that he could see the flickering shapes of more horses giggling and laughing in the white foam. He turned back to the horses, flicking his tail uncertainly, torn between what he had always done and wished to do. The horses felt him wavering and trotted around him in circles, flowing into a smooth canter like the beings of the waterfall they indeed were.

“Solutions are simple, do it now! Act now before things get far worse! Cadoc, dragon, being free with us can’t be worse than being with your coven, can it?”

Cadoc couldn’t possibly argue with them there and he felt a sense of resolve burst into life within him. Why should he stay with the coven? There were no physical bonds keeping him there – he could leave! He could be free and he could live the way he wanted to, with no needless killing, just the life he had always wanted for himself.

The ceffyl-dwr sensed his new found resolve and jumped excitedly from side to side, whinnying and laughing happily. In answer to them, Cadoc felt a laugh of his own bubbling warmly up from his stomach, a sound he had not heard from his own muzzle in a long time. He looked at the horses, his eyes glinting with determination and his teeth bared with the strength of his new found purpose. Idris rose up on his hind legs and batted Cadoc’s nose gently with his hoof, in a gesture of companionship.

“Now, go back to your coven and tell them that you are leaving. And come with us!”

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“Is this the life you want us to have, Jared?” He snarled at his leader, baring gleaming white fangs in an open threat. “Will you drive us into battle yet again to take more lives? I’ve seen what life is and this isn’t it – this isn’t living.”

“So why follow us?” Jared replied coolly, carefully getting to his feet and shaking the dust from his scales. “You say we all have a choice in life. Perhaps it’s about time you made yours and decided where your allegiances truly lie.”

Cadoc studied Jared’s outwardly calm expression for a few seconds that seemed to stretch into the very essence of time. And in those few scant seconds he saw his once friend for what he truly was. A murderer, a traitor and a liar with false promises silken on his tongue. A being that rejoiced in death and suffering.

The substance of a demon.

Underneath Jared’s calm mask Cadoc knew that he was seething with constrained hatred and fury, but he would never be goaded into visibly submitting to it. He would never admit these feelings, even to himself, choosing to justify his brutal actions with twisted reasons and riddles that only ones like him understood.

Cadoc smiled sadly, finally understanding what he had to do, although it would mean leaving behind the only life he had ever known.

“I think I know where they lie, Jared. They lie far away from you and your thirst for blood. Far, far away.”

Jared drew in his breath with a hiss, snaking his neck back in shock at what he realised Cadoc was about to do. Cadoc squared his body proudly and faced the others who were staring at him in disbelief.

“You know I’m leaving. You can come with me if you want, but don’t ask me to stay here, because I cannot live this way any longer.”

“Cadoc...” Sadaki whispered, shrinking back into the shadows with his eyes wide with fear. “We cannot. I cannot leave the coven. Every dragon must belong to a coven. You must belong to a coven.”

Cadoc shook his head sadly and closed his eyes; he had hoped that Sadaki at least would see why he was doing this and that what he was proposing to do was possible, that it could be done. He knew his friend had some compassion left – he was the youngest and the least tainted by Jared’s poison. But as he saw his friend tremble and press himself against the rock as if he needed the feeling of something solid for reassurance, he knew he couldn’t force him to leave with him.

“Then this is goodbye, Tadej, Sadaki,” Cadoc growled forlornly, dipping his head in a respectful gesture towards his former comrades. “I hope you fare well.”

He took to the air, leaving all behind far more swiftly than he could have imagined possible. It had almost been too easy to abandon the coven, but hearing Jared’s frustrated roar at his tail as he soared away made him sure that he had made the right choice, at last.

He was striking out on his own for the first time in his life. Well, not completely alone.

The two silvery ceffyl-dwr galloped over the land beneath him, tossing their manes in delight at their game of chasing the dragon as he flew harder and faster, laughing as they fought to keep up with him.

He watched them for a moment, seeing how they plunged through a river only to emerge squealing with their manes dripping, and he knew that he was like them now: wild, untamed and free. He had no cares in the world – now he flew where he pleased. He was bound to no one now.

Idris lifted his head heavenwards and whinnied loudly in a challenge to Cadoc as his stride lengthened, increasing his already reckless speed over the land. Cadoc grinned, baring his teeth in a friendly smile and pumped his wings harder, pushing further ahead of the ceffyl-dwr. The little horses put their heads down, pounding out a rhythm against the ground as they attempted to outpace the dragon in the sky; Cadoc laughed.

Finally, he could say the words he had longed to for so many decades and hear them ring true. *He was free.*